



Support for farmers during hard times

January 2026

Farmers and rural communities face many risks to their business, including natural disasters, drought, pests and diseases, and other market disruptions. Australian Government programs and services can assist farmers as they plan for, manage, and recover from these shocks.

Support in your area

If you need support, there are many people and organisations you can talk to about your options. They include:

- farm industry groups
- banks and advisers, such as agronomists and accountants
- federal, state and local governments
- charities and other non-government organisations.

To find out about help available if you are affected by a disaster or natural event, visit the Disaster Assist website at disasterassist.gov.au.

Farm Household Allowance

The Farm Household Allowance (FHA) is available to farmers and their partners in financial hardship. The program provides practical support through a package of assistance, including fortnightly payments and additional allowances, such as Health Care Card and rent assistance, case support and farm financial assessment.

The program also includes a \$10,000 activity supplement to develop skills and increase capacity for financial self-reliance.

To discuss eligibility and ways to apply for FHA, call Farmer Assistance Hotline on **132 316**.

For more information, visit agriculture.gov.au/fha.

Rural Financial Counsellors

Rural Financial Counsellors (RFC) are qualified professionals who can provide confidential support that is unique to the farmer's situation, at no cost to the client.

Rural Financial Counsellors have the skills to transition clients out of immediate financial crisis and will listen and help support the farmer to assess the business viability and make informed decisions to take the necessary steps to get out of financial difficulty. For immediate help with household expenses, facilitation of farm debt mediation, or emergency assistance following a natural disaster, your local Rural Financial Counselling Service can provide information on the full range of government assistance programs.

To find your nearest RFC, visit agriculture.gov.au/rfcs or call **1300 771 741**.

Mental health, social and emotional wellbeing support

Dealing with economic, climatic, and social pressures can affect farming families' wellbeing and mental health. Help is available.

- Call lifeline.org.au on **13 11 14** or 13 YARN on **13 92 76** for immediate crisis support.
- Visit medicarementalhealth.gov.au to find reliable information, advice, and free or low-cost phone, online and face-to-face mental health services and supports.
- Find other mental health related resources at health.gov.au.

Regional Investment Corporation concessional loans

The Regional Investment Corporation (RIC) delivers the Australian Government's concessional loans to the farming sector, offering low-cost, low-interest rate loans. Farmers and farm-related small businesses meeting eligibility and lending criteria requirements can apply for loans of up to \$2 million for farmers and up to \$500,000 for farm-related small businesses.

For more information, visit ric.gov.au or call **1800 875 675**.

Farm Management Deposits (FMD) Scheme

Primary producers experiencing hardship can access previously lodged FMDs to supplement business cash flow. An FMD account allows tax deductible deposits to be made during years of good cash flow that can then be withdrawn during lower income years. Primary producers affected by drought or natural disasters, such as floods, may be able to withdraw their FMDs within the first 12 months of deposit without losing any taxation benefits.

For more information, visit agriculture.gov.au/fmd.

Other taxation measures

The ATO offers a range of options to assist businesses in financial difficulty. For example, they may be able to help people with:

- adjusting pay as you go (PAYG) instalments to better suit their circumstances
- providing more time to pay, including payment plans with interest-free periods.

Primary producers may also be eligible to spread or defer profits from the forced disposal or death of livestock and insurance recoveries.

Individuals experiencing financial hardship can contact the ATO directly via the Emergency Support Infoline: **1800 806 218**.

For more information, visit ato.gov.au/Business/Primary-producers.

More information

Learn more about the support you can access on agriculture.gov.au/ruralsupport.



Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge the continuous connection of First Nations Traditional Owners and Custodians to the lands, seas and waters of Australia. We recognise their care for and cultivation of Country. We pay respect to Elders past and present, and recognise their knowledge and contribution to the productivity, innovation and sustainability of Australia's agriculture, fisheries and forestry industries.

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